

TALKING STAGE

A Comprehensive Summary

INTRODUCTION: WHAT IS TALKING STAGE?

All right, the first thing I will talk about is the obvious title - which is just an attraction - Talking stage.

Talking stage is an invention of TikTok. And it is actually the informal early phase of a potential romantic relationship. It is describing the informal early stage of a potential romantic relationship.

Do you understand it now? With that, I want to tell you there's absolutely nothing like a talking stage. Talking stage is the invention of the devil. But here's the idea. What really is the talking stage? I defined it to you, right? But what is it in practice?

Today, it has become the practice where people now actually polydate. What do I mean by polydate? So a guy can be talking to five girls and say that they are doing a talking stage. But we are going to restaurants with our talking stage, we are going to the cinema with our talking, we are visiting our talking stage at home. So it means we want the benefit of a relationship without taking the responsibility of a relationship, so that whatever happens later, you will say it was not a relationship.

PURPOSE FOR THIS TEACHING

First of all, I want to set a foundation; I'm talking to born-again Christians.

I have no wisdom to give you if you are not born again. If you are not born again, everything I will say to you today will fight against everything that you know before or things that you agree with.

In the Bible, there are only three relationships that are acceptable:

1. Friendship,
2. Courtship, and
3. Marriage.

GOD is completely against this concept of the modern-day invention of Talking Stage.

Again, What's the talking stage? I'll tell you in practice. It is supposed to be the preliminary conversations that happen between a man and woman who have a potential romantic interest.

Does GOD want you to have potential romantic interest? The answer is no. GOD wants you to marry.

And now you say we are doing this talking stage so that you will discover whether you like the person or not. No, that's not the way.

So we'll talk about how a Christian is supposed to make that decision of who they should marry, and when they have seen a person that they like, what they are supposed to be doing.

Because here's the thing: The closest thing to hell fire is a bad marriage. If you see the things that the Bible used to describe a bad marriage, you'll be scared. For example, the Bible says it is better for a man to live on the edge of a rooftop, than for him to live in a bad marriage. (Proverbs 21:9)

If GOD gives you a blank cheque to write down one person who you want to marry, whether the person is married now or not, and GOD says to you, I will bring the person for you, who would you marry?

My question is, if GOD is standing in front of you and GOD says, give me one name of a human being that you would like to marry, who would it be?

****At the end of this class, you are going to go back to the name and check whether you would still marry that person.***

IS VALENTINE'S DAY A SIN?

Should we celebrate Valentine's Day?

The "spiritual" ones among us would say Christianity is built on love. Christianity is already "*For GOD so loved the world that He gave HIS only begotten Son...*" So we are not supposed to celebrate love specially because christianity is a love walk.

If you celebrate Valentine's Day, you do not sin. If you don't celebrate Valentine's Day, you also do not sin.

Some people on the far left, for them to prove that they are spiritual, On a day like this, they want to do the most spiritual thing they can ever do, which is pray - Pray the lust away. Let nobody deceive you, you cannot kill lust by prayer. Don't tell yourself that to kill masturbation, you have to pray 12 hours in tongues.

When you finish praying for 12 hours in tongues, you are now more vulnerable and energized to masturbate. Why? When you engage in spiritual activities like praying in the spirit, and singing in the Spirit. (especially singing in the spirit), what you receive is grace (which is divine enablement) to do what you were thinking before.

This is why praying in the Holy Ghost is never the answer to any form of lust.

When it comes to matters like love, sex, and marriage, it's not a question of "if". It's a question of "when". That's why the preacher man in Songs of Solomon said "*daughters of Jerusalem awoken not my love until the time is right...*" (Songs of Solomons 2:7). It is a function of time. There is a time it should wake up.

So don't go and pray that GOD will kill your desires. No. GOD does not do all those things. He doesn't answer those kinds of prayers. So, if in this season, you say "This period, I'm just horny...GOD please take this horny away..." Nothing will go away.

Romans 14:4-5 KJV

"[4] Who art thou that judgest another man's servant? to his own master he standeth or falleth. Yea, he shall be holden up: for God is able to make him stand. [5] One man esteemeth one day above another: another esteemeth every day alike. Let every man be fully persuaded in his own mind."

So you see, the idea of picking any day to celebrate anything. It's a decision between a man and his GOD.

My birthday is March 12th. I can decide that I don't want to celebrate myself on that day. I can say, "*From this day forth, January 1st is the day I will celebrate myself.*" I did not sin against GOD.

That's why when you celebrate Christmas on the 25th of December, and another Church celebrates theirs on October 1st, it is their Christmas.

If I want to celebrate the Resurrection on December 14th, what do I want to celebrate? Is it the day of resurrection or the resurrection itself? Is it the day of Pentecost I want to celebrate or that we receive the Holy Ghost? So don't fall into that conversation that those people who celebrate Valentine's day are carnal.

It is the fact that you think that what we want to do is have sex, that's why you are saying that we should not celebrate Valentine. But when GOD celebrated love, He died for all of us. We have so reduced it in our head and we have all believed it. Pre-marital sex has been going on long before February 14th.

People that will have sex on Valentine's day made up their minds before then. And some of them are already in autoplay. If you preach today, they will accept the message, but they will still have sex.

So if you delegate Valentine's day as war against pre-marital sex, you already lost because the body is already going where the mind was.

WHO SHOULD HAVE “TALKING STAGE”?

1 Corinthians 7:36 KJV

“But if any man think that he behaveth himself uncomely toward his virgin, if she pass the flower of her age, and need so require, let him do what he will, he sinneth not: let them marry.”

“If she passes the flower of her age” there is “if she is mature”. And he went further and said “if needs so require let him do what he will...” and “what he will” here is not a blank cheque, because this is the scripture some people use to justify pre-marital sex.

When you see the full colon, it is about to tell you the interpretation of what was said previously, and in this case, the answer is, “let them marry”. So in a proper church, if the church leadership notices that a boy and a girl can't control their sexual desires, it is the duty of the church to facilitate the marriage quickly.

“If she passes the flower of her age” is an old Greek word (HUPERAKMOS) meaning “if she is mature” and that means that talking stage (which I will now use as a synonym for the sake of this conversation for courtship) is actually for mature people.

Mature people means people who have attained individuality in life. Listen very carefully. A lot of people have no business in having a talking stage or liking a girl or liking a boy. What I'm saying is that a lot of people are not fit (equipped or mature enough) to marry. Therefore they should have no business in a talking stage.

But why do we still do it? Because the problem here is not lack of truth. The problem here is that we know the truth but we think that we can bypass the system. And the Bible says every man who thinks that he can trick GOD or outsmart GOD, he says he has outsmarted himself and he will suffer. (Galatians 6:7)

DEAL FIRST WITH LONELINESS

It is because some of us lack real-life social skills and that is why the only relationship we know is boyfriend and girlfriend. But what is really lacking in our life? The real word is **friendship**.

Every healthy young man and young woman is supposed to be in a community of friends, and that takes away the thing that is pushing you into a relationship primarily, and that thing is loneliness. If your only form of companionship is a sexual spousal relationship, you are actually lacking in the area of esteem, because what you want is consistent affirmation about who you are or what your body looks like.

So what you do not have is real friends, and what you need is not a boyfriend. What you need are friends. So as an individual, you need at least three solid friends.

Do you know why this is the foundation? Marriage is a lifelong friendship. Many people think of marriage as an everyday sex affair, until you marry and now realize that it is not.

I'm very sure some of us think that the people who are married are having sex every day. Until they tell you that in the last month, they have not been able to think of having sex because there's a whole lot going on.

You meet a person and then it's the body heat that pushes you. You will probably start having a lot of sex. The thing that causes that is infatuation. And infatuation has a lifespan of six months. Once it passes, you begin to see the person as you should have seen the person.

This has been the conversation, and this is why many people, especially believers, married who they did not like. In fact, there is no place they cheat in a marriage like in the church. Absolutely no place. And the reason is because Christians sometimes behave foolishly when it comes to the subject of marriage. They make their marital choices with the wrong parameters.

People say that GOD told them that this is their wife. Anybody, including a pastor, that says GOD told him this is his wife, I say to you that a large percent of them are liars.

The only time GOD gave man a woman, the man told GOD "it was the woman that YOU gave me..." From that day GOD said "He that FINDETH a wife..." (Genesis 3:12). (Proverbs 18:22).

So, as a young Christian girl, if anybody in this church, even if he's already a pastor, comes to tell you that the LORD told me you are my wife, don't believe them. Because he will manipulate you. That is the beginning of gaslighting - Don't allow anybody gaslight you with the Holy Ghost.

Back to it...

Friendship.

What you need is friendship. I said marriage is a lifelong friendship, and not about daily sex.

Once the friendship is not there, there is no marriage. And I said that people cheat in church more than everywhere else, because church people do not have the right parameters. And when they enter inside it, because of our strong culture in Nigeria and our faith being against divorce, we remain in the marriage, then we find other ways within the marriage to "sort ourselves out."

Marriage is a lifelong friendship. So you want to ask yourself, do I have good friends?

Anybody that is coming around you that wants to marry you, ask them who their friends are and how long have they been friends.

People of good character have long-time friendships.

Don't let the person tell you what he is. Observe what he is. People of good character have Long-time friendships.

Friendship is a dress rehearsal for marriage. If you don't have friends that can talk to you, friends you can trust to tell you the truth, that you can knock each other's head and just gist, you will never be ready for marriage. Marriage will shock you. You can see marriage simply as that friend that you are sleeping with.

WHO IS MATURE?

As I said before, courtship is for mature people. How do I know a mature person?

A Mature Person is an Individual

A lot of people grow in age, but don't grow in mind. Maturity is how grown your mind is. An individual is a person who can:

1. Gather the right information,
2. Process the right information,
3. Make a decision from the right information gathered, and
4. Stand by their decision (and its consequences, whether good or bad).

An individual is a person who can gather the right information, then process it, think it through, then make a decision by himself, and stand by it.

If he is not making his decision, he is not an individual; he is a puppet. Somebody is puppeting him and that puppeteer is the person that you are going to marry. Because in marriage, *"let us stay in so and so place..."* *"My mommy said that we should stay in this area."* You have married a mommy's boy.

I speak to people as a pastor. Sometimes they're talking to me, they don't even know that I can hear who is talking through them. I'm hearing somebody's voice through them because of who they interacted with before they met me. And that's how I know that you are not an individual.

So when some people tell me, "I like this person", I say to them, "You don't have the right to like because you can't make your own decision." Such a person needs to first become an individual.

What does it mean to stand by your decision? It means to take responsibility for the consequences of your choices, good or bad.

The thing went south, I did it. Have you seen footballers when they miss, they cause a goal or miss a penalty? The responsible ones, they apologize to the team, and they immediately get to the work to get to do it.

Anybody who blames somebody else for their choices is a child and should never be married.

When you do things together, and you observe they said or did something wrong. When the thing goes south, and the leader, or the pastor, or the boss asks, "Who did this thing?" What is their response?

If they are blaming someone else or making it a group failure, that person is not an individual. If they are not able to stand by their choices, that person is going to blame you for their life's failure.

Because when things go wrong inside this marriage, and things will go wrong, they will now tell GOD, "It is the woman that You gave me..."

That kind of person, if you ask him why did this thing happen? And his response is "Are you not the one that told me to do it like this?" He or she is already throwing the blame, and is not mature.

What makes a person mature?

Their ability to gather information, process the information, make their own decisions, stand by their, and you know what it means to stand by decisions, is to take responsibility for the consequences of their choices, good or bad. You broke a plate in your house, you quickly swept it and threw the thing away, so that nobody would know the plate was broken. You are going to be a bad husband.

That statement means that you will not take responsibility for your choices. You are the one who will bring it up when your parents come back. "Mommy, I'm very sorry, something happened when you went out. Mommy, please sit down first. I broke your favorite *Ewere* (traditional clay pot)..."

Your father left you with his car key, and went out with his friend. You came back with the car scratched, and you're saying "Maybe some of the children that were playing in the neighborhood used nails to scratch the car."

Maturity is that once your father comes in, you give your father his favorite drink and say, "I'm sorry dad, but something happened. I scratched your car..."

He may be angry at that moment, but your father will know something about you, which will affect his estimation of you. He would know that he has a responsible son. He may not say it out loud, but he will respect you, and he will entrust the car to you next time.

A Mature Person is Financially Responsible

Another way to know somebody who has passed their flower, that is, they are mature, is they are able to do three of these things:

1. Make money,
2. Manage money,

3. Multiply their own money.

I want to beg you. Some of the things I'm saying, you will quickly be using it as a lens to look at somebody else. Please don't. Use the things I'm saying as a mirror to look at yourself. If you are not capable of making money, kill every attraction you have.

Love gives, but love gives its own things. Read it again, it will sink.

The fact that you take your sister's stuff and give it to your girlfriend doesn't show anything apart from that you are not mature. When Christ loved you, HE did not give an angel's life: HE gave HIS life. Love gives, but love gives its own things. And take note: it's not the size of the gift, it's the cost of the gift that matters.

The cost of the gift is not the price of the gift. The cost of the gift is what it cost me to be able to buy it: What I put in to buy it.

I had to take one urgent job, and I worked all night to be able to earn the money to buy you this. So it's not just the money they paid me. It's the fact that because I wanted to buy you a Valentine gift, I stayed up all night.

It's the fact that I walked two hours to where you live, that is the cost.

Again, love gives, but love gives its own things.

Love doesn't steal to give you.

So madam, the yahoo boy that is giving you ridiculous amounts of money and buying you a phone, it's not his own thing. He does not love you. He cannot love you. If he loves you, he will work decently because of you. Love gives, but love gives its own things.

But I am also saying that a person is not an individual just because he is able to make money. If he cannot manage his money, he cannot manage you. Because if he cannot manage his money, it means he cannot manage his life.

It was his life he invested to make money (We invest and exchange our time and our skill; our time is our life). So if he cannot manage his money, he cannot manage his life, and if he cannot manage his life, he cannot manage another person's life.

Make money, manage money, and multiply money. Anybody that cannot account for the money that they earn, he cannot account for your life. That is the truth. And this is more for women.

Ask him Where is your money? Do you get what I'm saying? You ask some people how much is in your savings now? And they feel attacked.

A Mature Person is in Control of Their Time

***Another way you know a person is mature is to ask them are you in control of your time?
Anybody who is not in control of their time is a child.***

Now that I've given you the criteria, check yourself and check the person that you are in a talking stage with. They are going to lie to their mother and their sister and their uncle to buy you Valentine gift, and you think they gave you something? They didn't give you anything. Check what the gift he gave you or she gave you cost them.

If a man who earns 100,000 gives you a gift of 30,000, you don't compare it to the fact that this guy who steals 2 million gave you a gift of 300,000. Are you seeing the difference?

WORK COMES FIRST BEFORE MARRIAGE

Galatians 6:4-5 KJV

"[4] But let every man prove his own work, and then shall he have rejoicing in himself alone, and not in another. [5] For every man shall bear his own burden."

GOD your father in whose image and likeness you were made, HE gloried in HIS work. The Bible says to us in Genesis one that at the end of each day, GOD will look at what HE did and GOD will say it is what was good.

Ephesians 2.10 says that you are GOD's workmanship. You know what it means? It says that the proudest thing that GOD has is HIS new creature: you. GOD's proudest moment was after the death of Christ: People receiving Christ. That was his work.

Let every man also glory in his work...

The Bible says let every man prove his own work. He says and then shall he have rejoicing in himself alone. But one of the things you want to know is they separate the boys from the men. He didn't say let boys glory in their work.

If as a person you are not able to say, "This is my work and it is good", leave courtship alone.

GOD gave man work before he gave man woman.

Unknown to many people, marriage is for work. GOD gave the man the wife because of the work HE gave to the man. And it's called help meet - someone to join you to do the work that He gave you. So, man and woman, if you have not decided what your life's work is, forget about marriage. You will die unhappy if you don't do this.

Marriage, according to GOD's design, is the support system for work.

One of the leading causes of bitterness in the world is that people decided who they would marry before they knew what they were supposed to do with their lives. And when they now knew what they were supposed to do with their lives, they now realized that they took the wrong person along.

It is where you are going that determines who you will take along.

So if you have already carried somebody and you don't know where you are going, there will be trouble. That is why when a guy and a girl meet in the club, everything is sweet. They drink, they have wild sex, they take drugs. The one person becomes born again, and is trying to tell the other that she wants to pursue her purpose, and then there is a problem because your purpose will be taking you farther and farther away from your spouse.

Now, when I speak of what comes before marriage, I didn't ask you if you have a job. I did not ask you if you have any handwork.

What is your life's work?

That is, what is the thing that you were born to do? And this is where service, especially service in church, comes in. Because there you will put all your natural gifts to work, which will now help you begin to see your spiritual gifts, which will in turn help you begin your assignment in life, and that's what will now determine who you would want.

Galatians 6, verse 4 and 5.

“4 But let every man prove his own work, and then shall he have rejoicing in himself alone, and not in another.

5 For every man shall bear his own burden.”

It says he should what? Prove it. If he says, “I'm a designer...” Show me what you're designing. Show me how they use your products.

If you choose a person before knowing your life's work, when you finally find what your life's work is about, you will most likely see that you have picked the wrong person, and there, frustration will kick in.

Your priority should be purpose before marriage. So what should I be focusing on right now? My life's work, because this is what will help determine who I will marry.

Nowadays, the girl just needs to be pretty, marry, and her husband will start a business for her. This is how the world thinks in reverse.

If you are moving closer and closer to GOD's Word, what happens is that, if the marriage was built on a wrong foundation, and anybody grows spiritually, your spiritual growth becomes a threat to the bad marriage and you will be unhappy.

So if you are reading this and you don't know your life's work, what I'm saying is, forget relationship! Pursue your life's work. Once you find your life's work, GOD will bring you a spouse.

How will He do that? He will put it in your environment. Remember, marriage is a primary support structure for your life's work.

Earlier, I said that 99% of people who say that GOD told them, they are lying. Why did I say that statement? It is because in truth people are looking for voices. People want to hear, but they don't know what the Voice of GOD is. The Bible is the Voice of GOD. The written Bible is the ultimate Voice of GOD.

Most of the way people expect GOD to speak, GOD does not speak that way. I teach this when it comes to how to choose who to marry.

The principle has not changed:
"Grow up spiritually and marry who you like."

But is that not carnality? First of all, what is carnality?

Carnality and spirituality are two opposite attitudes that a believer has. Spirituality is an attitude. Carnality is also an attitude. So what is carnality or spirituality?

Carnality is the way a person thinks. Spirituality is also the way a person thinks. So carnality or spirituality is how much the way a person thinks. It's how a person, how much the way a person thinks aligns with the Thoughts of GOD.

This means that the Thoughts of GOD is the gauge for spirituality or carnality. So if you want to measure whether you are spiritual, then you check how much the way you think habitually aligns with the way GOD thinks.

So what is carnality? It's a state of the mind. What is spirituality? It's a state of the mind. This is where a lot of us fail.

Once you don't get this, you will marry wrong. You will think that the girl who prays the loudest songs in church is a spiritual person, whereas she may be a senseless person. Because his name is Christian and he's in church, carrying the pastor's Bible, you think he's a Christian. But he's not.

Another thing I must highlight is that you have to take responsibility for your decision. Don't blame any church in this world for your spousal choice.

There were so many options in that church, but this is the one you attracted. Why? Because, in a local church, people of like minds will always find themselves.

So spirituality is a state of the mind. So if you see somebody in church, he's a person that sweeps the church regularly, comes early, leaves late, you now think that that is what makes him a Christian, then you are grossly mistaken.

In fact, let me say this to you. Some people serve faithfully because they are poor.

After pastoring for 10 years, I can tell you this: I have the grace of waking zombies: idle men. Men that have no purpose, no direction. They come into my ministry. I teach them. Now they want to do something. Now they want to be something. They have something that their life is about.

All of a sudden, their service starts dwindling because they have now found something. So their service in the beginning was out of what? Poverty.

How I know people who have a heart for service are people who already have found purpose, found work, have money, are able to earn, and they are still making the sacrifice to serve, because service is sacrifice.

Your availability may not be that you are serving GOD. Your availability may be that you have nothing to do.

The Bible makes it very clear. It says in Romans chapter 8 and verse 6, it says, for to be carnally minded is death, but to be spiritually minded is life and peace.

So what is spirituality? Mind. When Paul was to describe spiritual growth, he said be renewed by the transforming of your mind. (Romans 12:2). That's spiritual growth.

Why is this important? What am I explaining?

Marry who you like.

So the question is, who do you like? Because what you like and who you like will show whether you are spiritual or you are carnal. That is the truth.

So what is spirituality or carnality? It's your habitual way of thinking. Your habitual way is not how you think one day. It's how you think everyday. And this is what will determine what you like, and who you like.

Your emotions are the expression of the state of your mind.

Let me ask you a question.

Have you ever liked somebody before until you got a piece of information about them? And when you got that piece of information about them, they were still 6'2", and they could still sing, but in your mind, this person became worthless to you?

What changed? The information you received corrupted their file in your mind's eye. Now once you click that guy's file, you see error 505, but the guy still looks handsome.

That lady that day, see her figure. They now told you that she was married two times before, and she has a child that is with her mom. What happened? Same person, but file is corrupted.

The way you think of the person changed, and emotions went away. So your emotions show whether you are spiritual or carnal.

Your mind needs to be controlled. So spirituality is about controlling your mind with the Word of GOD.

If what you claim to like are the good reports, excellent things, like you see Philippians 4 verse 8, what it means is that those are traits of godliness. But if your parameters of liking a woman are the carnal things, like her height, her complexion, her figure, the size of her breasts, the size or the shape of her hips, trouble awaits.

None of the things I mentioned are the content of her mind. We are not how we look. We are how we think. You know that passage of Proverbs? *"As a man thinketh in his heart, so is he."* (Proverbs 23:7)

The woman is not the size of her breasts or hips.

See, the problem with us is this; We look out for the outside before we begin to look inward. And it happened to Samuel.

Samuel went to the house of Jesse to anoint a king, and he saw Eliab. He said, "Surely, this is the LORD's anointed..." But it was not so.

Proverbs 31:25 says that charm is deceitful and beauty is vain.

I know you like a tall girl with good hips. But I'm saying to you, that as you are growing spiritually, your will change. If you look only on the outside, you will miss GOD.

Any characteristic that a person did not earn by obedience to the Word of GOD is not a trait to look out for in marrying him/her.

So what are you looking for? Power. Virtue. Knowledge. Patience. Tolerance. Brotherly kindness. Charity. That's what you're looking for.

As a man that's been married for 10 years, take my small experience. Anybody you marry for their physique, when you see the inside, you will no longer see the physique because you don't want to look at them. You don't want to think of them. You don't want to hear them. Some of you have been there before.

Character is the real beauty. So the question is, what kind of person do you like? In liking somebody, what are the things that tickle your fancy? So Peter said about both men and women, 1 Peter chapter 3, verse 4 and 5 in the NLT.

Character is beauty. When we say a person is beautiful, we mean that the person has what? Good character.

So Christianity is not about making a decision of who to marry. If you decided to wait till the junction of marriage to practice Christianity, you have already failed. Christianity is about the way you think before you get there. The whole idea of Christianity is that GOD wants to work inside you so that you can think like Him.

When you are able to think like GOD, you will choose like Him. Throughout the Bible, you see GOD making choices of men. And the parameters were very interesting.

So, it is a continual process of changing your thought pattern that GOD is about.

GOD had a vexation in Isaiah 55.

He said that we are looking to get His ways and His results, without His thoughts. The way to get His ways, that is, His results, is to have His thoughts. You want a blissful marriage without GOD's pattern of thinking. It doesn't work.

DESIRES CHANGE

Growing up, I had all types of desires. But guess what? I soon discovered that my desires changed. Desires change.

This is why, if GOD grants us all our desires, we will kill ourselves. So GOD does not answer some of your prayers about your spouse that you are praying, because GOD knows that next week you would like another game. It's a spiritual law.

In James chapter 1 and verse 5, it says, If any man lacks wisdom, let him ask. Verse 6, it says, "But let him ask in faith, nothing wavering because he that wavers is like the wave of the sea, tossed to and fro...".

So when you tell GOD today that you like this girl, but next week you tell Him that you like another, which one will He give you now?

James 1.7 says, The man that has not made up his mind on who he likes, he will not receive a wife.

In your lifetime, you would have all types of desires, and God will not answer all of them. Why? Because your mind is evolving.

Desires change because of their sources that are changing. Once you understand the sources of desires, you will not make a big deal about your desires. But on the other hand, if you don't understand the sources of desires, you will be deceived by your desires.

All the physical characteristics I have liked in a woman, I maturely admit to you that they came from the sources of information I was exposing myself to in that season.

When I was growing up, I had a lot of older guys. We had this compound where our family was upstairs and I had four much older guys living in the flat above us and another set of five older guys living right below us. So imagine the masculine conversations, right?

In running errands for them, we would hear some mature conversations they used to have. When one of them liked a girl, they would talk about the girl nonstop. So at that time, I knew what a fine girl was, based on their definition of beauty.

DESIRES ARE BORN FROM INFORMATION

The proof that an information has entered you is that it births a desire in you. Anything that is your desire today is actually an expression of an information that has entered you yesterday.

Have you ever liked only slim girls, but later moved on to liking only chubby girls? Has it happened to you before?

I'm telling you, your preferences when it comes to the girl you like, you were not born with it. Somebody taught you directly or indirectly. Some of your choices of men came from TV programs. If the TV series you are watching change, your perspective will change.

So once you understand the source of desire, you will not make a big deal of some of your desires.

But what I'm questioning you today is, where did your desire come from? Desires are just proof of information that you have internally processed.

So when you say, "I want him to be at least six feet tall..." "I want her to have a figure eight..."

These are not the things to specify when you are telling GOD about who you want to marry. Those things are carnal mindsets.

But does this thing mean that GOD will give you an ugly person? The answer is what? No. But don't present these things to GOD as your desires, otherwise, you will definitely deceive yourself.

Many people think that the will of GOD is that, for example, I like this thing, and anything that is against what I like is the will of GOD. That is not true.

There is absolutely nothing attractive in an unbeliever. One of the things we saw here today is that what you like or don't like is a proof of your spirituality or what? Carnality. So that thing that you find attractive in an unbeliever is a proof of what? Carnality.

So 2 Corinthians 6 and 14 (NLT) tells us that we should not be unequally yoked with unbelievers.

So if you want to enjoy your courtship, if you want to enjoy your courtship, one thing that you must do is,

1. Flee youthful lust.

If you do not flee youthful lust, your talking stage is an audition for a sex partner, not a courtship. That is why both of you have not spoken for up to a week and he is already asking to see what you are wearing.

You can be in a relationship with the person for three years and not know the person. And one of the strongest causes of this is youthful lust. How does that happen? Say, for example, she's in university. Maybe the guy is in town for business (working).

Then she comes on Friday to see the guy, to go back to school on Sunday evening, depending on the location of the school. So they have these two nights together.

They go and hang out in the lounge, a bar, a pub. They eat food. Sometimes they drink alcohol, you know. They go home and they have sex. They sleep off. Saturday morning, they do almost the same thing. On Sunday, she returns to school.

They can do this repeatedly for three years. Then they say they have been in a relationship for how long? Three years. You don't know him.

And then you decide to marry. You now take pre-marital class. And then, before the class is over, you drop out because you never really knew each other

So, your courtship can be destroyed by lust, because once it is there, lust is a dictator. It will begin to tell you what to talk about. You begin to ask questions like,
“What is your favourite sex position?”

You can know a person's favourite position, but you don't know their position in life. You don't know where they are going.

SEXUAL COMPATIBILITY

There is such a thing as sexual compatibility. Sexual compatibility is that a man and a woman would have sex and can either end up feeling empty or full. Although it applies to both the man and the woman, it depends largely on the woman: This compatibility depends on the quality of friendship between the man and the woman, as the quality of the friendship determines how the woman's body receives the man.

That's why I say to people who are married, the most important ingredient in marriage is what? Gist. The quality of friendship depends on the quality of the gist. See, sex is volunteered in friendship. Sex is a form of caring for a person.

That's why when you say you are a girl, your best friend is a guy. When they break his heart, you will care for him. And one day in caring for him, you will give him your body.

Man and woman are not supposed to be best friends.

It is not Biblical. When Joseph was told by Mary that the Holy Ghost impregnated her, he did not go and tell Miriam.

In the history of bestie, sex is the problem. Man and woman can only be friends in a community of friends. Man and woman exclusive friendships hardly work.

Same sex friendship is safer for better accountability. If as a lady, you tell your male friend that you are feeling horny this period, you are planting the seed of sleeping with you in him.

Let the men be accountable to men. Let the women be accountable to what? Women.

Back to it...

Youthful lust destroys the talking stage.

Anybody that you don't want to sleep with, don't talk to the person after 10 o'clock. You know why? As a human being, all your hormones are different at night. Even an ugly boy is fine at night. His voice will change texture.

Any non-family conversation, have a curfew for it. Many of you here have fallen into sexual situations before, because of small lines like "Have you eaten?"

You expose your heart, and then the person is already inside and you end up doing illogically what you would not do logically.

This is why it is you and your girlies that should be talking in the night. Boys, it's you and your guys that are talking in the night.

Lack of real friendship is why you are awake at night and it is only that guy you can talk to. Before you know it, you switch to video call, and then things get messy.

2 Timothy 2 and verse 22, The King James version said, "*Flee youthful lust...with them...*" So, you know what? You cannot by yourself overcome lust.

Lust is something you overcome in a group. Where does lust come from? Companionship. How do you get rid of lust? Right company.

Again, where does lust come from? The company you keep. That's why you cannot say that your best podcast is a podcast that promotes premarital sex and you think you can have the right desires.

The Bible says, "*Flee also youthful lust, but follow righteousness, faith, charity, peace with them that call on the Lord out of a pure heart...*"

Not them that just call on the LORD, but the ones that do it out of what? A pure heart. So it did not just tell you to flee youthful lust, it told you how. The way to flee youthful lust is to make sure you have good examples in front of you. So GODly examples are the way out of lust.

Listen to me, it is your association that lust comes through. That is the absolute truth. You cannot say you will not be influenced in life. You can only choose what will influence you.

That's why I said that once access is granted, influence cannot be denied. Your doctrinal persuasion itself is a matter of your company. If the people around you do not believe in healing, you will not be healed when you are sick.

If the people around you do not believe in prosperity, you cannot be prosperous. It is that strong.

So anybody that you're exposing your ear to over time, the spirit that has a grip on him will soon have a grip on you. Whatever has a hold of him will have a hold. That's why you must stay with balanced and honorable people.

1 Corinthians 15.33, it says "*Be not deceived. Evil communication corrupts good manners.*"

Do you know the problem with this scripture? It is speaking to people who already have good manners.

If you keep company with people who have evil communication, he said you would what? He said you will not see the blessing of God. Remember Psalm 1:1.

The interpretation of that verse is,

"Cursed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the ungodly."

"Cursed is the man who stands in the way of sinners."

"Cursed is the man who sits in the seat of the scornful."

The scornful people in this context refers to dishonorable people. And the sad thing is that the person in question is not scornful, but he is in the midst of scorners. He is not talking but he is hearing.

There is a story in 2 Samuel 13 about one guy called Amnon. He too was a son of David. He had an inordinate affection towards his sister, Tamar. His sister was so fine. She was the sister of Absalom, the first son of David.

The Bible said that he had that feeling but did nothing about it. If you see 2 Samuel 13 verse 3, the Bible says, "But Amnon had a friend..."

After he said in verse 2 that he liked the girl, he didn't do anything or didn't know what to do. Verse 3, he said but Amnon had a what? A friend. What we do is a result of our what? Association. This is the guy that told him to feign sickness and ask for his sister to cook for him and bring it to his room.

He eventually slept with the girl, and the moment he slept with the girl, the scales fell from his eyes and then he pushed her away. And then the girl killed herself, and her brother, Absalom, heard of it, and killed Amnon.

If Amnon did not have evil communication, he would not have died the way he did.

I said who you like is a result of your association. What you do also is a result of what? Association.

So what is the focus? Godly friendship.

Courtship is not marriage. Why did I say this? Some of us have wrongly invested emotions. Do not love anybody until the man of GOD says to you, "I now pronounce you man and wife."

The bible says, *"Husbands, love your wives..."* (Ephesians 5:25). Not your talking stage. Not people in courtship. Not your boyfriend. Why? You are single until the priest says I now pronounce you husband and wife.

To love one another in the church is different from loving your husband. To love your wife is to give yourself without any caution and unreservedly to a person. It's to give your life to the person, and you don't do that in courtship.

What is the purpose of courtship? Knowing a person. Remember that, the use of courtship is to know a person. Love your wife, not your girlfriend. This statement means some things are reserved for marriage.

Courtship is not the place where you suppress or hide your weakness. Courtship is the place where your uniqueness is celebrated. So if you have to be hiding a part of you to be in a relationship with a person, that is not your wife.

If you laugh loudly, but around this person, you hide your real laugh, you are not yourself. And once you are not yourself, don't force it. That is why people come and say you changed. No, I didn't change. This is who I am.

It's the way you eat normally that you should eat when you go on that date.

Whoever told you that if you serve a lot in the house of GOD, GOD will reward you with a good marriage, lied to you. Because one of the frustrations some people now have is how long they've been serving and GOD has not given them a spouse.

Please be delivered by the truth: You may serve GOD but you will still choose your husband. And you can be a good person and have a bad marriage if you don't put in the work.

So what do I do in courtship?

- 1. Have meaningful conversations.**

If the conversations that are between you and a person that you like are useless conversations, understand that you cannot do life with that person. You are sending memes to each other, but can't talk about something meaningful, useful. If you start talking about something useful, they're uncomfortable. Do not engage. In fact, disengage.

"What's your favorite color?"

"What's your favorite food?"

These questions are for a secondary school crush. You don't need a crush.

Because in marriage, you can like watery beans, and your intended likes fried beans, and both of you will be married. So even if my favorite color is black, and your own is pink, it doesn't change anything. I'm talking about the meaningfulness of the conversation.

You people spoke all night, let's edit what you said now. How was your day? So where did you go today? So it is the meaningfulness of the conversation that makes for friendship, because what do we do in courtship? We build friendship.

How do we build friendship? First thing, have meaningful conversation. What is the purpose of the talking stage? To build what? Friendship.

And to have meaningful conversation, Honesty must be the bedrock. Stop lying to one another.

If you notice a person lies unprovoked, just to pitch themselves to you, just disengage. If you are not their teacher, don't try to correct them. It brings unnecessary friction and arguments.

Honesty and vulnerability is required to have meaningful conversation, which is required to build a friendship. With the sole purpose of what? Of courtship.

Do this in honesty and don't be judgmental.

And you yourself, on the other hand, create a room where you're a friend because the person is a friend. Create a room where a person can tell you what they really think. Many times, we are the ones responsible for how honest a person can be with us. Create an honesty room around yourself.

Also, stop speaking Christianese. "The LORD told me to tell you" is manipulation.

There's a certain level of naivety and anticipation that you must create for marriage. And how do we achieve this? I said build friendship.

2. Build bonds.

How do you build bonds? Do things together.

In marriage, you are going to be thinking and planning how to pay the next rent, how to pay school fees, the car that you want to buy.

So, marriage is about executing projects with your lifelong friend. So, if you can't talk or work with a person, forget it. This is where cheating starts from, because you can discuss work with a babe at the office, but you can't talk about work with your wife.

Do things together. Do a project together. Save together. Get a crafting machine, build it together. You know, even if it's those lego cars that you have to assemble together, try together.

This is how you know a person. It's not sex. Women are not written in braille, you don't have to touch them to know them. When you assemble that thing together, play Monopoly together, you will learn their character.

How do you build bonds? Build things together. Attend conferences together. Go on group games with your friends. That's why you have to be in a group of friends. Game nights. Where you see how your intended spouse reacts to losing the game.

Go to each other's family together. This one will save you many troubles.

It's not when you're done with pre-marital class, you then say you have not seen her dad, your dad has not seen them. No, the father is supposed to know you long before. The siblings are supposed to know you as well.

But what people call the talking stage nowadays is that we are trying to force ourselves to know a stranger.

Formula for marriage:

Be in the church.

Have friends in your church.

Marry one of the friends.

Do charity together. Do community service together. Two of you come and volunteer in a free school: One day a month, two of you come and volunteer, so that you can see how your intended spouse reacts when one of the children provokes him.

You will be able to tell if he has long suffering. And without long suffering, you can't marry anybody, because all of us have bad character. The only way to deal with the bad character that must come with the person you want to marry is that long suffering is growing in you. Because to marry anybody is that you are going to tell GOD that, "I don't know when they will change, I don't know if they will change, but I'm going to marry them."

So courtship is not when you change anybody. Courtship is when you accept a person's good, bad and ugly.

Another thing to do in courtship,

3. Clarify your goals in life.

Because many people don't know what to say, that's why the next thing to say is, "What's the color of your underwear?" They themselves don't know their goals now. So what are their goals? You say that you want to do a Masters, but what do you want to do with a Masters? Why do you want a degree in public health?

Those are how you clarify goals.

Ask questions.

"I like to live in Lagos."

Why do you want to live in Lagos?
What will Lagos achieve for you?

Those are things we talk about in the courting stage.

The talking stage is where you explain your passion. Why? If you want to marry a man, know what drives him, not just what he drives. Our passions are what drives us. It will be the reason he wakes up.

So because we don't know what to do in courtship, we are doing all sorts of rubbish.

Additionally, what to do in courtship?

4. Know each other's vision.

What will you achieve that will make you say that you lived a satisfactory life?
What is your vision in this life?

Because what is courtship? Knowing how I'm supposed to support you to live. People finish this life and say I have lived. How will I support you to come alive? If I don't know that, I cannot be a good spouse.

So what are we supposed to be doing in courtship? Help me understand your vision. Help me understand your "what". Write the vision, make it plain. This is the thing that will help you know who to take along.

What do you do in courtship?

5. Find out where your goals meet.

Even if they don't meet. Find out how to complement each other's vision.

Marriage is not where the woman gives up her vision so that the man's vision will thrive. If it was a right fit in the first place, the actualization of the man's vision is supposed to give room and a platform for the woman's vision.

So you harmonize each other's what? Vision. And ladies, ask him when he tells you his vision, where his vision is in GOD's Vision? Because if his vision is to be the richest person in his hometown, he does not have vision. What he has is jealousy.

GOD's vision is simple: Evangelization and discipleship of the whole world (1Timothy 2.4)

This thing you want to achieve to say, I have lived that. Where does it fit into GOD's vision?
What to do in courtship? Where is the allowance for me in your goals?

What do we do in courtship?

6. Develop common friendships.

Do you guys have a common friendship?

A common friendship is very revealing because you will begin to see each other through other people's eyes. You will see each other in a way that you cannot by yourself see each other.

What do we do in courtship? Feedback as opposed to criticism. The difference between feedback and criticism is "when" and "how".

They are actually the same content. When and what? First goal. And you too that they want to give feedback, Drop the defense.

What do you do in courtship? Adopt common interests.

Two more things. What do you do in courtship?

7. Pray for and pray with each other.

What do you do in courtship finally?

8. Help each other to be established in the local church.

Any spousal interest that is weakening your commitment to your local church, that's bad for marriage. If you have the right person, you will serve GOD more, because marriage is for serving GOD. It's for the multiplication of power to fulfill ministry. Literally.

Courtship is work.

If we just enjoy the conversations at night, it is very likely we are not in courtship. Likely we are not in a good courtship, because in explaining your passion to somebody else, sometimes you will know that your passion needs to pass on.

Courtship is more mental work than you think it is. The problem is that we are mating for our body. We are choosing what our body likes. But in marriage, you are choosing what your soul needs.

Your spirit already has a husband, male and female. JESUS is your husband: He that is joined with the LORD is of one Spirit.

Remaining only two parts of you: body and soul. The soul can never be led by the body.

That's why when you have chosen dark and handsome for the body, the soul is unhappy. She's sad but she has a rich, fine husband. But when you choose for your soul, the body goes where the soul goes.

When the two became one, it is the souls that were merged.

“Isopsuchos” — Greek for likeminded, of equal soul.

They now have one soul. So it is not your body that needs a husband. Remember your spirit already has a husband.

So, back to number one. Number one is flee youthful lust.

How do you flee youthful lust? Company.

Good company is the only defense against youthful lust.

Your conversation should not revolve around sex all the time such that once that one is taken out of the picture, we cannot talk again.

What should we talk about? I listed them for you already.

Also, be mindful of when and where you meet your love interest.

Both of you go to the cinema, and the lights are turned off, and they turn on a high capacity AC for only 20 people, yet you say you don't know what's going to happen.